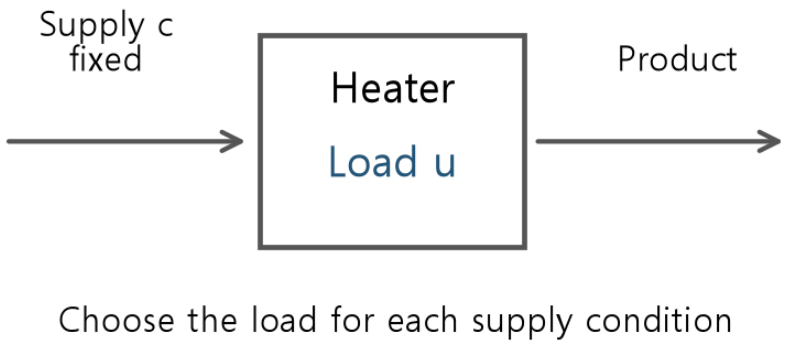
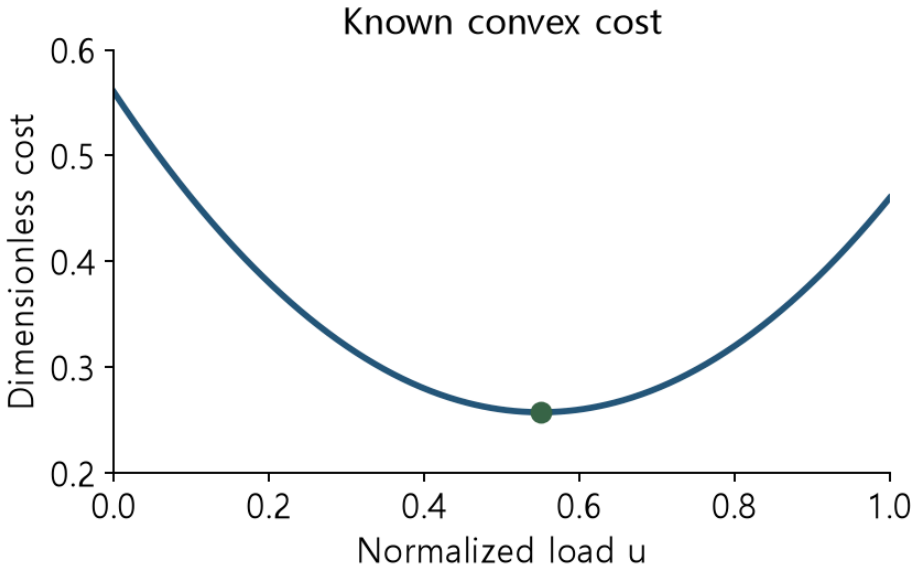
Week 7: Designing Model Structure for Optimization

Utility cost models and repeated operating decisions

A changing supply condition requires a new heating-load decision. When a neural network predicts the cost curve, its structure also affects the optimization used to select the load.





We will preserve convex cost structure while selecting the load.

Model choice and optimization formulations

Weeks 5 and 6 represented a fitted general ReLU network exactly as an MILP. This week imposes convexity in selected inputs during model design.

We begin with a known convex cost. Reactor concentrations and yields are not assumed convex.

Structural restrictions reduce the function class, so evaluate prediction error together with the resulting decisions.

Learning objectives and deliverables

1. Separate decisions from fixed context and check ICNN sign conditions.
2. Explain objective-value equivalence and the conditions for a ReLU epigraph LP.
3. Calculate counterexamples involving inequality direction, negative weights, and variable context.
4. Validate a small fitted ICNN decision by forward evaluation and a reference function.

Decision variables and fixed context

Choose a normalized heating load u, while fixing measured supply composition or ambient conditions c. Freeze model parameters θ before optimization.

$$\min_{u \in U} f_\theta(u; c)$$
$$U = \{u : Gu \leq r\}, c = c_{obs}$$

Convexity here concerns u. It does not establish convexity in c or θ.

Convex functions and sublevel sets

A convex function lies below the line segment joining two function values.

$$f(\lambda u + (1-\lambda)v) \leq \lambda f(u) + (1-\lambda) f(v)$$
$$0 \leq \lambda \leq 1$$

For convex f, the constraint f(u) ≤ b defines a convex set. The reverse inequality generally does not. This distinction determines valid LP uses.

Boyd and Vandenberghe, Convex Optimization, §§3.1-3.2 and 4.1-4.3

ICNN input connections and sign conditions

$$h_0 = 0$$
$$h_k = \mathrm{ReLU}\left(W_k h_{k-1} + A_k u + b_k\right)$$
$$f(u) = a^T u + d + w^T h_K$$

Constrain every entry of W and w to be nonnegative. Direct input weights A and a, and biases, may have either sign.

ReLU is convex and nondecreasing. These conditions preserve convexity in the inputs through the layers and output.

Amos, Xu and Kolter, Input Convex Neural Networks, ICML 2017, pp. 146-155

Layerwise convexity derivation

The first layer is a maximum of an affine function and zero, so it is convex. Assume every component of the previous layer is convex.

With $W \geq 0$, their weighted sum is convex; adding an affine input connection preserves this property. Applying convex, nondecreasing ReLU preserves it again.

The output condition $w \geq 0$ serves the same purpose. Negative slopes in direct input connections remain affine and do not break the argument.

Negative weights and input convexity

Negative weights on hidden activations remove the sufficient condition.

$$f(u) = -\mathrm{ReLU}(u),\ -1 \le u \le 1$$
$$f(0) = 0 > (f(-1) + f(1))/2 = -.5$$

Direct input weights need not be nonnegative: ReLU(−u + 0.4) is still convex. Identify which connection each restricted weight belongs to.

Sign constraints during training

After a gradient update, project W to max(W, 0), or parameterize W = softplus(V) using free parameters V. Apply the same rule to output weights w.

Here softplus parameterizes positive weights. Hidden activations remain ReLU during inference.

Inspect the actual fitted weights. Training a general deep ICNN in its parameters is nonlinear and nonconvex.

ReLU graphs and epigraphs

$$h = \mathrm{ReLU}(s) = \max(0, s)$$
$$h \geq 0, h \geq s$$

The two inequalities describe the region above ReLU. They allow h = 10 at s = 0, so they do not represent the graph equality itself.

To use these lower bounds in an LP, it must be possible to reduce the auxiliary activations to the actual outputs, and the objective and remaining constraints must permit that reduction.

An extended LP for a ReLU ICNN

Use these constraints for a finite ReLU network with frozen weights.

$$h_k \geq 0$$
$$h_k \geq W_k h_{k-1} + A_k u + b_k$$
$$t \geq a^T u + d + w^T h_K$$

Add $Gu \leq r$ and minimize t. With W, $w \geq 0$ and linear remaining expressions, this is an LP without binary variables.

Replacing the activation by softplus can preserve convexity, but not an exact representation by these finitely many linear constraints.

Forward recovery and objective-value equivalence

At fixed u, a feasible first-layer h dominates the actual ReLU output. Induction using $W \geq 0$ gives the same result at every layer, hence $t \geq f(u)$.

Conversely, the true forward activations with $t = f(u)$ satisfy every constraint. These two inclusions establish the exact epigraph.

The optimum of min t agrees with the objective at the selected u. Auxiliary variables that do not affect the output may remain slack even at an optimum.

Applicability by output use

Output use	Assessment
min f(u)	Use an epigraph objective
$f(u) \leq b$	Adding $t \leq b$ gives the exact input feasible set
$f(u) \geq b$	Adding only $t \geq b$ does not enforce a lower bound on the true output
$y = f(u)$	The output graph equality is generally nonconvex
max f(u)	The same LP argument does not cover convex maximization

Also inspect any other constraints that favor larger h or t.

A two-hinge cost model for hand calculation

$$f(u) = .4 - .6u + h_1 + .5h_2$$
$$h_1 = \mathrm{ReLU}(u - .4), h_2 = \mathrm{ReLU}(u - .7)$$
$$0 \le u \le 1$$

This dimensionless cost example supports direct numerical checks. Its successive slopes are −0.6, 0.4, and 0.9.

The minimum is at the first slope change, u = 0.4, with f(0.4) = 0.16.

The hand model LP and a cost cap

$$\min_{u,h} .4 - .6u + h_1 + .5h_2$$
$$h_1 \geq 0, h_1 \geq u - .4$$
$$h_2 \geq 0, h_2 \geq u - .7, 0 \leq u \leq 1$$

A cost cap of 0.25 leaves the feasible input interval [0.25, 0.625]. Bound the affine output expression above to obtain this interval in the LP.

The lab checks the minimum value 0.16 and forward agreement.

A counterexample for an output lower bound

On $0 \leq u \leq 1$, let $f(u) = \mathrm{ReLU}(u)$ and minimize u subject to $f(u) \geq 0.8$. The true optimum is $u = 0.8$.

$$h \geq u, h \geq 0, h \geq .8$$

The relaxation permits $u = 0$, $h = 0.8$. An inflated auxiliary variable lowers the cost. A small MIP gap or an LP optimal status cannot detect this modeling error.

Counterexamples for output rewards and graph equalities

Minimizing $-h$ for the same ReLU makes the epigraph LP unbounded when h has no upper bound. The actual $f(u)$ lies in $[0, 1]$, and $\min -f(u) = -1$.

For $f(u) = |u|$, graph points $(-1, 1)$ and $(1, 1)$ have midpoint $(0, 1)$, which is not on the graph.

Transferring cost-epigraph equivalence directly to concentration equalities or output rewards changes the problem.

PICNNs and fixed context

A PICNN imposes convexity on only part of its input. The path processing supply context c may be nonlinear, while the decision path in u must satisfy the required sign conditions after c is fixed.

The next page uses a sufficient form in which context determines layer coefficients. The paper’s gated construction can also be interpreted this way at fixed context.

Amos, Xu and Kolter, Input Convex Neural Networks, ICML 2017, pp. 146-155

Conditional coefficients and LP construction

$$h_k = \mathrm{ReLU}\left(W_k\left(c\right) h_{k-1} + A_k\left(c\right) u + b_k\left(c\right) \right)$$
$$W_k\left(c\right) \geq 0, w\left(c\right) \geq 0$$

Evaluate the context path once at observed c, then freeze its coefficients. With linear remaining decision expressions and constraints, construct the ReLU epigraph LP.

Optimizing c as well can introduce nonlinear products W(c)h or A(c)u. Fixed-context results do not imply joint convexity or an LP.

Conditional versus joint convexity

$$f(u;c) = |u - c| - .1c^2$$
$$0 \le u \le 1, 0 \le c \le 1$$

At fixed c, the optimum is u = c. The lab solves separate LPs for c = 0.2, 0.5, and 0.8.

Along u = c, f = −0.1c². The endpoint average is −0.05 but the midpoint value is −0.025, violating joint convexity.

Fitting a known convex reference function

$$q(u) = (u - .6)^2 + .1u + .2$$

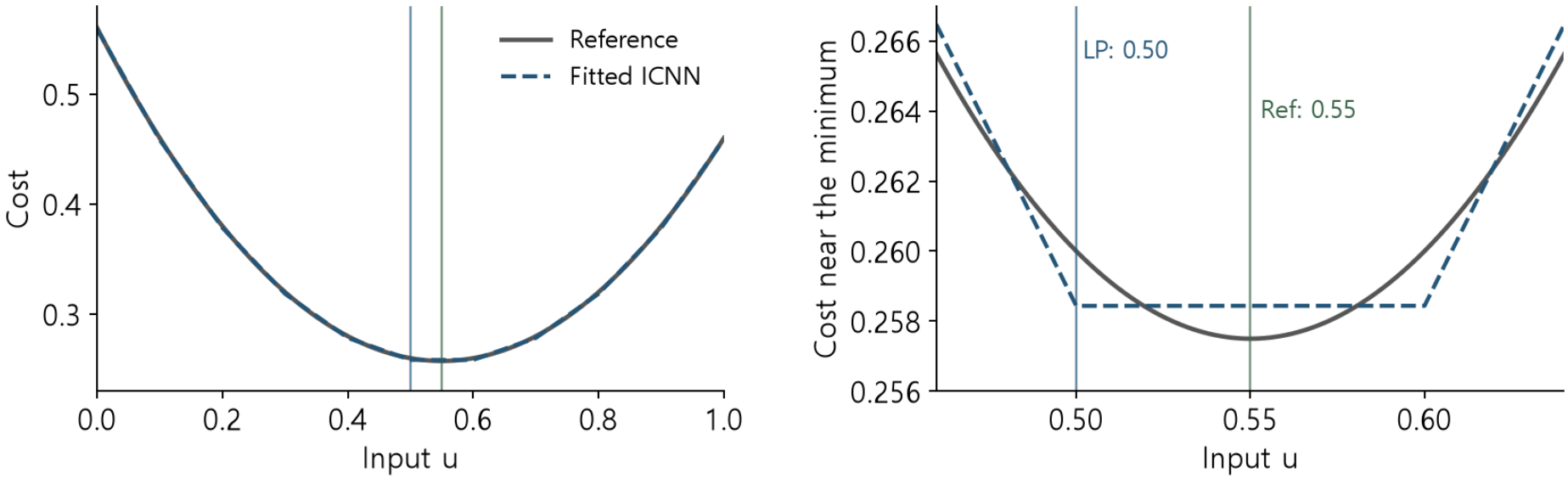
$$f(u) = b + au + \sum_{j=1}^{9} w_j \mathrm{ReLU}(u - \kappa_j)$$

$$\kappa_j = .1j, w_j \geq 0$$

Fit coefficients at 41 evenly spaced inputs and evaluate at 200 separate midpoint inputs. With fixed knots, this lab uses bounded linear least squares.

This shallow ICNN with fixed knots is a special case with convex training. The conclusion does not extend to general deep-ICNN training.

Fitted curve and selected load



Independent-evaluation RMSE is 0.000760. The LP selects u = 0.50, while the reference minimum is at u = 0.55.

The reference cost difference is 0.0025. Close prediction curves can still have different minimizers.

Checks on an LP result

1. Save the input domain, context, scaling, and model weights.
2. Check W and w signs, objective direction, and every use of outputs.
3. Evaluate the original network at the chosen u and compare with the LP objective.
4. Separately evaluate the reference objective and constraints.

The fitted-model LP objective is 0.258437, while the reference cost is 0.260000. Their difference is surrogate error.

Choosing a model structure

Target and conditions	Approach to examine
Known convex cost minimization	ICNN or fixed-context PICNN
ReLU, linear output, linear outer constraints	Epigraph LP after checking its conditions
Concentration equalities or nonconvex response	General surrogate with an appropriate NLP/MILP
Weak evidence for convexity	Compare structural prediction bias and decision errors

Running the lab and checking outputs

```
python -m pip install -r requirements.txt
python week07_lab.py --output-dir my-results
```

Extract the code bundle before running. It writes results.json, fitted coefficients, training.csv, and heldout.csv.

Automatic checks cover the hand optimum 0.16, fitted sign conditions, LP/forward agreement, the output-lower-bound counterexample, and the unbounded example. The notebook runs the same functions in stages.

Assignment: equivalence conditions and decision error

1. Add a cost cap of 0.25 to the two-hinge model and calculate both endpoints of its feasible interval.
2. Run the output-lower-bound counterexample and record the falsely allowed u and its true output.
3. Change fitted knot spacing from 0.1 to 0.05; compare prediction error and reference decision loss.
4. Explain why c is fixed and which output uses your formulation permits.

The companion provides derivations and short answer checks.

Companion and primary sources

The Week 7 companion works through epigraph equivalence, LP matrices, sign-constrained fitting, and counterexamples.

Amos, Xu and Kolter, Input Convex Neural Networks, ICML 2017, pp. 146-155

Boyd and Vandenberghe, Convex Optimization, §§3.1-3.2 and 4.1-4.3

SciPy bounded least squares · SciPy HiGHS LP interface